Takeaways

- **Four BJMC students were among the 19 dead on the ground**
- **It became the war room where the crash victims' tests and documents were processed**
- **Its psychiatry faculty is enabling students to cope with trauma, grief**
- **Every student is back on campus, calls for a new site gets no steam**



small religious ceremony preceded it—something to soothe the nerves, even if the memory of burning bodies that students, staff and faculty witnessed on that ill-fated Thursday will likely linger in their psyche.

For three weeks after that, resident doctors also had to counsel the grief-torn relatives of passengers, through their harrowing wait for charred body parts from the debris to return from DNA analysis. "Final year students are used to dead bodies. They've worked on post-mortems. But the first and second year students were badly affected," says Dr Kavin Kotadiya, a final-year intern doctor. "We didn't let the four whose roommates died return to their empty rooms. We shifted them. Many students went home for a fortnight, but are now gradually resuming routine," he adds.

For a week after June 12, BJMC dean Dr Minakshi Parikh's office hosted state ministers and bureaucrats. Now she gently marvels at the resilience of the college community. There have been some murmurs from parents about whether the college should be shifted, but Dr Parikh says not a single student has moved out of the hostel.

THE HEALING

"When classes resumed, the psychiatry faculty members collectively addressed over 200 students to educate them about trauma and grief: the cycle of denial, anger, depression and acceptance," she says. They are observing students closely and will reach out individually if symptoms of PTSD appear.

It takes a toll on the care-givers too. "Many of us have intense flashes of the burning aircraft and body parts; the dry empty eyes of a man who lost his wife, mother and daughter. But we all come back everyday, because this is our life," says Dr Prajapati. The source of their trauma is never out of sight, nor out of mind. Bang in the centre of their universe, there lies the crash site, dark and impenetrable, guarded round-the-clock by local police. Life is taking wing amidst that, tremulously. "We look up every time an aircraft takes off," says Dr Prajapati. ■

▶ RAJASTHAN

THE CM REDRAWS LINES IN THE SAND

One day he's down, next he's rearranging his entire bureaucracy. It's been a rollercoaster, but the CM has regained upper hand

By **Rohit Parihar**

THE CAMEL RIDE HE TOOK on the sands of Shergarh, Jodhpur, in early July must have reminded Bhajan Lal Sharma of the ups and downs of life as a chief minister. The climate didn't seem propitious—on any front.

His powerful predecessors, Ashok Gehlot and Vasundhara Raje, were on the prowl—scarcely concealing their ill will. On top of that, the restive base of maverick Jat MP Hanuman Beniwal, founder-boss of Rashtriya Loktantrik Party (RLP), had just ruffled Rajasthan's political landscape with a hashtag storm: *#BhajanLalHataoRajasthanBachao* went the slogan, i.e. 'Remove Bhajan Lal, Save Rajasthan'. Over 130,000 posts had flooded social media. The pro-CM counter hashtag, *#RajasthanWithBhajanLal*, limped in comparison, with barely 6,800 posts.

THE NEED TO BE TOUGH

His sarkari PR wing clearly ambles along the shifting dunes like a camel. So it falls on Sharma, who goes blithely about his business with that similar air of unconcern, to periodically quell any sense of infirmity. There are two ways to read this rollercoaster. One, he does feel